Lakshmi, and the much-loved consorts of Rama and Krishna, Sita and Radha. To this we should add Shiva's sons and daughters, beginning with Ganesha and Kartikeya (the god of war, and known to the Tamils as Murugan), but accumulating over time, with the important addition in the South of Ayyappan, to say nothing of all those local folk *devas* and *devis* absorbed into one or other of these two great streams of Hinduism.

This new pantheon had also to take account of the myriad sub-sects and local sects within Shaivism and Vaishnavism, such as the yogis known as Naths or Nathas whose founder, Matsyendranath, was swallowed in the manner of the Biblical Jonah and so overheard the esoteric teachings given by Shiva to his wife Parvati. This rich diversity is what gives Hinduism its extraordinary resilience, its flexible capacity to be all things to all men and women.

Spearheading this great transformation in the Tamil South were two rival movements of missionary saints of Vaishnavism and Shaivism, each championing their deity with the aid of their own agamic texts and supported by an ever-growing pool of writers, poets and musicians using their art to express their devotion and to inspire others. Among the Vaishnavas, bhakti found its most vocal expression in the twelve Alvars ('those immersed in god'), poet-saints drawn from every level of society from Brahmins to Shudras and even including in their number one woman saint, whose devotional hymns helped to create a native Tamil religious literature largely but not wholly free of Sanskrit.

Among the Shaivas the lead came from the sixty-three Nayanars, or 'masters', also known among Tamils as the Arupathu Moovars. These in turn were followed by a second bhakti movement promoted by mostly young celibate monks, many of whom took their lead from the Shaiva reformer Adi Shankara, born in Kaladi in present-day Kerala and said to have been disabled by dwarfism but a man of